

EYEWITNESS 1960s

A Woman in the NVA

Most women in the NVA joined in support capacities, accompanying the army as medics, supply personnel, or on bomb disposal teams. Whatever the role, life in the army was one of unrelenting hardship, shown by the experience of NVA servicewoman Phan Ngoc.

In all the companies, there were women between seventeen and eighteen years of age who had joined the army hoping to fight. When Phan Ngoc joined, she was initially assigned to cook and she describes her sense of anger and disappointment. However, a month later she became a sapper, working with dynamite, filling craters, and rebuilding bridges. As head of the company, she had twelve people working under her and was in charge of explosives.

A typical day for these women involved waking up at 5 a.m., but they worked during the day or at night depending on the bombs. They ate out of tins with branches because they had no chopsticks, cleaned the tins with leaves, and drank out of streams. At the same time, they tried to retain some elements of a normal life by carrying books with them and at night they would read or write home. Sometimes they put flowers in their hair.

“We sang a lot, because we believed that songs are louder than the bombs.”

PHAN NGOC, IN *EVEN THE WOMEN MUST FIGHT: MEMORIES OF WAR FROM NORTH VIETNAM* BY KAREN GOTTSCHANG TURNER AND PHAN THANH HAO, 2008